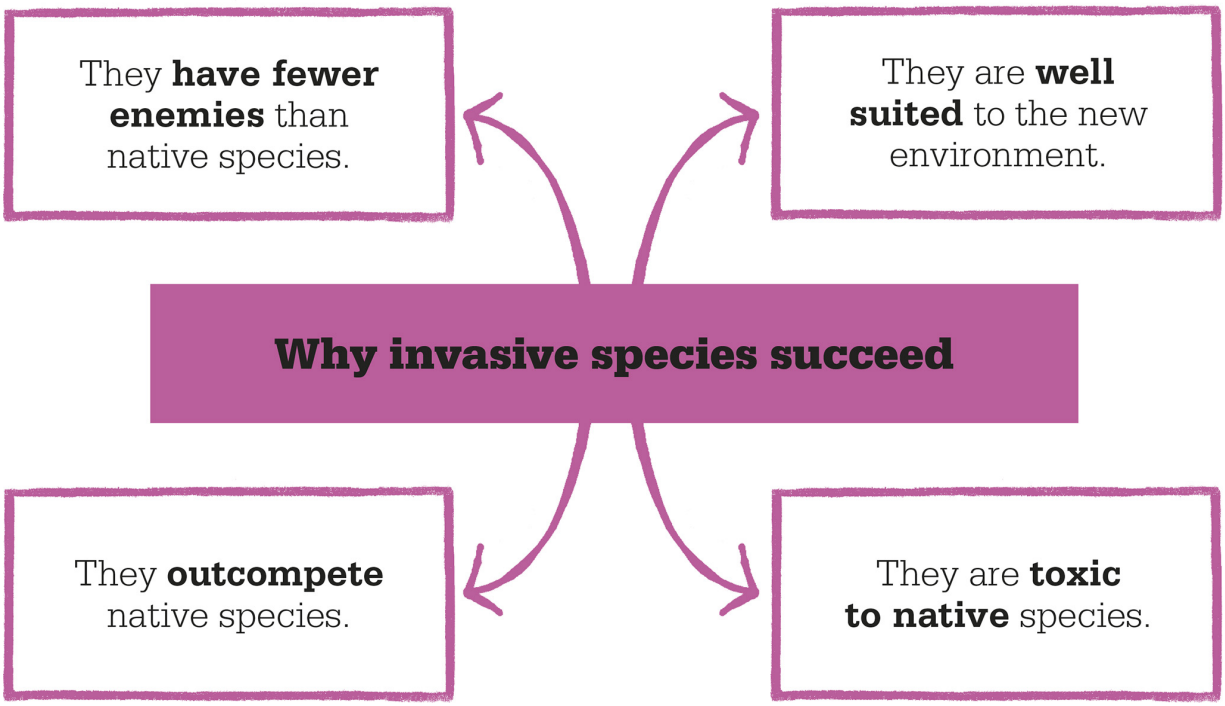


Read accessible description

Plant invaders

One plant that appears to support multiple hypotheses about the success of invasive species is garlic mustard (*Alliara petiolata*). Native to Europe, western and central Asia, and northwestern Africa, it was brought to North America by early settlers to use in cooking and medicines, and rapidly spread. Continued infestation has affected the growth rate of tree seedlings and reduced the native plant diversity, leading to changes in the forest ecosystems invaded.

In its native range, garlic mustard is consumed by as many as 69 insect species, but none of these is present in North America. This lack of predation and the plant's invasive success provide support for the enemy release hypothesis. Garlic mustard also successfully competes with native plants for resources, fulfilling the resource availability hypothesis. The plant even exudes secondary compounds that may "attack" native plants by inhibiting their germination and growth. This supports the "novel weapons"